

CHAPTER THREE

The Toolkit at Seventeen

Sofia had been getting texts from her friends for years that said variations of the same thing.

Hey Sof. I am having a hard week. Can we talk.

Sofia I am freaking out about the SAT. Help.

Soff. Big fight with my mom. Need a brain.

Sof — my brother just got bad news. I don't know what to do. Can I call.

She had been the call-Sofia kid since at least seventh grade. Probably earlier. She had not noticed it was happening until somewhere around tenth grade, when she had counted, on one day, that she had had eight conversations with eight different people about something hard each of them was going through.

She had told her mom about this, that night, at dinner. Mom, I think I might be everybody's therapist. Her mom had laughed and then had stopped laughing and had said sweetheart, are you okay being everybody's therapist.

Sofia had thought about it.

I think so. I like it. But also — I am not sure I know where the line is. Between being a friend and being — something else. Like, am I supposed to be doing this. Am I qualified.

Her mom, who works as a respiratory therapist at the hospital and has been around real therapists and real doctors for years, had thought for a moment.

Sof. There is being-a-friend, which is what you are doing. And there is being-a-therapist, which is a job. The job has rules. The job has training. The job has limits. Being-a-friend has different rules. You are being a friend really well. The thing to watch out for is — when a friend's problem is too big for friendship, you tell them to also see somebody who has the training. That is the line. You can be a friend AND tell them to also call a real therapist. The two are not in competition.

That conversation had been in February of sophomore year. Sofia had been carrying it around since.

She had, in fact, told a friend to call a real therapist twice since then. The first time was a girl in the grade above her who had been telling Sofia, on a regular basis, that she had stopped eating much. Sofia had listened. She had also said, after the third conversation, I am going to keep being your friend through this. But this is bigger than me. You need to tell your mom or call your doctor. I will be in the room with you when you tell your mom if you want. But please tell somebody who is trained. The girl had cried for an hour and then had told her mom. The girl had been seeing a real therapist for a year and a half now. She was doing better. She still texted Sofia sometimes.

The second time was a boy in her grade who had been telling her, in pieces over a few weeks, about being scared he might hurt himself. Sofia had — Sofia, who had been building her toolkit since first grade — had known exactly what to do. She had said I am going to walk you to Ms. Calloway right now. We are going to do that together. Right now. And they had. Ms. Calloway had handled it. The boy had been seen by professionals within an hour. He was okay. He was in college now. He had texted Sofia in August: Sof. First week of college.

Doing fine. Thanks for the walk to Ms. Calloway's office that day. I think about it. — D. She had cried when she got the text.

She had not told anyone about that text. The text was hers.

Senior year was going to be different. She knew it would be. Half the cohort was leaving in August. The texts she was used to getting — the Soff, big fight, need a brain texts from kids who were now down the hall or at home — were going to start coming from kids who were on the other side of the country, six time zones away, in dorm rooms she had not seen.

She did not know yet how she felt about that.

She was, she had begun to realize, possibly going to be a therapist someday. Or a social worker. Or a school counselor like Ms. Calloway. The shape was there. She had been doing the work informally for a decade. She had been reading psychology books since seventh grade. She had taken the AP Psych class as a junior — the youngest student in the class — and had loved every day of it. She had been quietly looking at colleges with strong psychology programs. She had not, until junior year ended, said this out loud.

She had said it out loud first to Mia.

Mia had been the right person to say it to. Mia knew her. Mia had also known her for nine years from far away, which meant Mia could see her from a distance the cohort could not. Mia had said, on the phone, Sof. Yes. That is the most obvious career thing I have ever heard. You have been a therapist since you were seven. Go be a therapist. Get the degree. Sofia had laughed.

Then she had said, but Mi. What if I am bad at it. What if I have just been doing the friend version of this and the real version is harder than I think.

Mia had said, very calmly, Sof. Listen to me. The thing that makes a good therapist is not being smart, although you have

to be smart. The thing that makes a good therapist is being a person who has, in their own life, sat with their own hard feelings and learned not to run from them. You have been doing that since you were six. You are ahead. You are way ahead. You are going to be a really good therapist. Trust me. I know you better than almost anybody.

Sofia had cried, a little, on the phone.

Mia had said, I am going to be there for graduation. We are going to have the in-person version of this conversation.

Sofia had said, okay.

That had been in July.

It was September now. Mia was in Pittsburgh, finishing her own senior year at her own high school. They had been texting more than usual in the last month — both of them on the edge of going to college, both of them processing what the next year would be. The text thread, when Sofia scrolled up, was so long that the phone could not show all of it at once. There were photos from sixth grade — Mia had sent a photo of a Halloween costume from a year Sofia did not remember. Birthday voice memos from every birthday since Mia moved. A photo of Mia's high school senior portrait, which Mia had sent two weeks ago, in which Mia looked older and the same and older and the same all at once, the way people you have known a long time always look.

Sofia opened the thread now. She was sitting at her kitchen table. It was a Saturday morning. Her parents were out at the farmer's market. She typed:

Mi. Ms. Calloway gave us five questions this week. One of them is "what are you scared of." I have been thinking about it.

She waited.

Mia, on the other end, was apparently also at her kitchen table at the same time, because the response came back in

under a minute. Sof! Ohhh. Five questions. What are you scared of.

Sofia typed:

I am scared that I am going to leave for college and the kids I have been the call-Sofia kid for are going to text me from their dorms and I am not going to be able to do it from far away. I am scared that I have only been good at this because I have been physically near everybody. I am scared I am going to lose my whole identity if I cannot help in real time. Mia took longer to respond this time. Sofia watched the typing dots come and go and come again.

Finally:

Sof. I have been your friend from far away for nine years. You have been being there for me through the phone since I was nine. You are GOOD at it from far away. You do not have a real-time-only superpower. The superpower is YOU. The you travels.

Sofia sat with that.

She typed back:

That is exactly what I needed to hear.

Mia:

I know. That is why you texted me.

Sofia laughed, alone at her kitchen table.

She typed:

I love you, Mi.

Mia:

I love you, Sof.

Sofia put her phone down.

She thought about the question — what are you taking with you when you leave — and she realized, in this small moment at the kitchen table on a Saturday morning in September, that one of the things she was taking with her was the version of

friendship Mia and I built across nine years and two states. She was taking it as evidence. Evidence that distance did not break things. Evidence that a person who became a real friend at seven could still be a real friend at seventeen, even after one of

them moved away. Evidence that she could be the call-Sofia kid for people who were five hundred miles away.

She picked her phone back up.

She typed, one more time:

One more thing. The bench-sign thing.

Mia:

Yes.

Sofia:

I was thinking. The bench sign Amara made. It is still up. They have replaced the lamination three times. The current version is in a fourth-grader's handwriting. But the bench is still the bench and the sign is still the sign. Amara made one small thing nine years ago and it is still doing work without her.

Mia:

Yes. So?

Sofia:

So I think — I think when I am a therapist someday, the work I am going to do is going to be like that. Not the loud kind. The bench-sign kind. Small permanent things. Signs that hold doors open. People who become call-them kids for the next people.

Mia:

Sof. Yes. That. Exactly that.

Sofia smiled.

She typed:

Okay. I am going to go do laundry. I love you. Talk later.

Mia:

Love you. Go.

Sofia put the phone down.

She got up.

She went and did laundry.

The toolkit was real and it was hers and it was going with her. The kids who texted her from dorm rooms in eleven months were going to get the same Sofia who had been the call-Sofia kid since middle school — just on a slightly different timezone. The job, when she got the degree

someday, was going to be a more formal version of what she had been doing since she was seven. The architecture was there.

She had been building it for a long time.

She knew, now, that building it and being it were the same thing. This is what twelve years of practice gives a person.

This is what Sofia is.